On June 2, Bharat Rashtra Samithi supremo K. Chandrashekar Rao (KCR) flagged off the 21-day decennial celebrations to mark the formation of Telangana. The "longest-serving Telugu chief minister" also crisscrossed the state to inaugurate a string of new projects. Of course, this being an election year, KCR spared no effort in highlighting his government's achievements, and the most visible of these are the irrigation projects. Telangana now irrigates some 7.5 million acres of farmland, and the CM is promising water for another 5 million acres. "This will help us achieve the target of irrigating 12.5 million acres. The progress is there for everyone to see. Our per capita income is now Rs 3.17 lakh, more than double what it was in 2014 when Telangana was formed. The GSDP is Rs 12.9 lakh crore, up from Rs 5 lakh crore in 2014," says KCR, trotting out the numbers.

The CM's minders say he is taking strategic steps to secure his party's success in the upcoming assembly election. The focus now is reportedly on specific communities and implementing policies that address their exact needs to ensure support. Meanwhile, in the run-up to the polls, the BRS is hoping that nothing rocks the ship—that the flow of investment remains steady and the rural economy revives through the slew of initiatives for farmers such as the Rythu Bandhu (investment support), Rythu Bima (group life insurance) and uninterrupted power supply. Except that the state is strapped for cash. With market borrowings of Rs 40,150 crore in 2022-23, the government's outstanding liabilities currently stand at 25.3 per cent of GSDP.



FLAG-OFF KCR and other party leaders at the Telangana Day function, June 2

PROMISES, PROMISES

Though the BRS has implemented several welfare schemes, KCR has not delivered on the promised unemployment dole. Filling up of vacancies in government jobs has also been relatively slow. "BRS is relying more on its relatively efficient delivery of individual benefits than on substantive across-the-board improvements of governance," says Harati Vageeshan, who teaches political science at the NALSAR University of Law, Hyderabad. "Their prospects can be dented by highlighting the failed promises, such as on providing quality public goods, creating avenues for meaningful employment, and lack of good governance in areas like revenue administration."

KCR IS FOCUSING ON IMPLEMENTING COMMUNITY-SPECIFIC POLICIES AND ENSURING INVESTMENT FLOW IS STEADY

Indeed, the opposition Congress, suddenly upbeat after the Karnataka slam dunk, and the BJP have focused sharply on three things: corruption, the broken promises and the tardy implementation of flagship schemes such as the two BHK housing for the poor. But the BJP finds itself hampered, as after the Karnataka debacle, any charge it now makes against the KCR government will ring hollow. Also, as E. Venkatesu of the University of Hyderabad points out, "As of now, there is no evidence of a strong anti-incumbency wave". KCR's rural connect, he says, especially with farmers and sections of